Case 03 · The decision: Roll Transparency Log vs Removal Sample Audit

The document that closes the case: the question, the two survivors, three rounds, the winner, and what it does not solve. Characters are fictional; figures come from the case's POCs.

The question

Who lets one person see, in time, what happened to their name?

To see means knowing what happened, why and when, before the appeal window closes. The Economist (31 October 2026) describes a revision in which more than 130 million names were removed from draft voter rolls, in a process run centrally, with software that did not show who was removed and why, and without a real chance to appeal for millions.

The path

Idea	Stopped at	Why
Duplicate Voter Matcher	Board	Another black box, like the one that deleted
Offline Mesh Messenger	Board	Risky for users, and outside the problem
Degree-to-Job Radar	Board	The data doesn't exist
Appeal Clock Simulator	Ideation	The napkin answered first (about 650 working days)
Exam Paper Time-Lock	POC	Leaks bypass the lock: 0 of 200 traced after retyping
Removal Sample Audit	Architecture	Nobody establishes an independent checker pool
Roll Transparency Log	Passed all	

Three rounds

Round	Sample Audit	Transparency Log	Edge
Mechanism	1,500 cases, ±1.7, coverage 94.8%	1M lines in 18.8 s, 20-hash proof, rewrite caught	Tie
Time	A district number after two weeks; Priya doesn't know if she's in it	SMS to Priya on the day, with code and 9 days to appeal	Log
Truth	Checker from the machinery; a quarter confirmed → estimate 11%, coverage 1.8%	The person checks their own line	Log

The winner

A log in which every change to the roll is recorded with one of 11 reason codes, cannot be altered quietly, is cosigned every minute by witnesses from different bodies, and whose subject hears about it the same day.

The surprise

The audit's blueprint left an empty box: "independent field checker". The answer is not another body. It is Priya. Whoever was removed knows best whether they still live at the address, and the log is what tells them to check. And the link runs the other way too: an audit that draws from the log gets a list nobody can change, and the appeals as ground truth.

What the winner does not solve

- A wrong reason, faithfully recorded.
- An appeal nobody hears in time.
- People with no phone who don't reach a booth.

Sources

- The Economist, "25 years of Narendra Modi", Briefing, 31 October 2026.
- RFC 6962 and RFC 9162 (Certificate Transparency).
- Reports on the Supreme Court of India's order to publish Bihar's removal list (August 2025).